

Jose Maria Barbeito

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HI 254

Final Essay

The Power of the American Dream

Since its birth in 1776, America has been a land that harbors people who dream. Whether they dream of riches or power, freedom or opportunity, it has beckoned to all with the promise of a better life. Throughout the twentieth century, America underwent dramatic change, starting off as a land where slaves worked plantations and growing into a country where every human has the opportunity to achieve their dreams. She went from a country that sat on the sideline of geopolitics on the world stage to being the greatest economic, military, and cultural power in the world. The US's global power and social equality rose steadily hand in hand as the century progressed, the two intricately connected to each other due to their driving force: the American Dream.

This "American Dream" is often referred to and has changed over time as America has grown, yet I would argue that it stems from the source of America: the Declaration of Independence. The most famous sentence in the document, which marked the independence of the United States from the colonial rule of the British, is recited often and reads "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness."

¹ This single line cements the core principle of America: a land where anyone can be anything they want. This grand ideal has traveled through time and infused every aspect of American culture, from the decisions made by lawmakers to the latest fashion styles. More importantly, it was refined into what we call "The American Dream" during the Great Depression by James Truslow Adams in his book, "Epic of America".² This American Dream has power, and is the leading force that drove both the rise of the United States to its position as the global superpower and its internal reformation of civil rights that brought voting, racial equality, and gender equality for all of its citizens.

We begin where most stories do, at the beginning. Specifically, the turn of the 20th century. It was during the early 1900's (and the 1890's) that there was a host of large fairs. Massive displays of the innovation and cultural growth that America was underground, all displayed for the public and other countries. This was America's debut into the world stage, the time when other countries started paying attention to the little colony gone rogue. Not only did the fairs, specifically the Chicago World Fair in 1893, show the spark that ignited the American

¹ The Declaration of Independence, 1776, paragraph 2

² Team, C. (2023, November 22). American Dream. Corporate Finance Institute.
<https://corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/economics/american-dream>

engine of progress, it inspired Americans citizens, showing them the power of American innovation beside imported novelties from far off lands.³

Yet American citizens were blinded by the light shone off the shining “White City.” The first decade of the 1900’s was filled with racial segregation and poverty of the working class. Jim Crow laws filled the south and black voting, which had been legal since 1870, was kept at a minimum through racial violence and disenfranchisement. Women were considered untrusted and could not vote, testify in court, or hold property. Workers had little to no workplace rights and were subject to 60 hour work weeks, no minimum wage, and weak child labor laws. The country was a place where the rich controlled the levers of power and workers were simply biological machines that could be replaced. Yet the desire for a better, more equal life strengthened as the Industrial Revolution began. In 1896 the National Association of Colored Women (NACW) was founded, advocating for the education and improvement of living conditions for African Americans, specifically women. In 1901, President Roosevelt started the Progressive Movement, targeting economic reform, regulation of industries with the Sherman Antitrust Act, the conservation of the beautiful lands the country had within its borders, large-scale social reform through reducing child labor and an emphasis on fairness through “Square Deal” rhetoric. Unions, such as the Knights of Labor, the A.F.L. and the Wobblies sprung up to fight for worker rights.⁴

It was these domestic changes that started the rise of America as a land of opportunity for immigrants. Waves of immigrants from across Europe and Asia began to flood into America, following the guiding light of the American dream, a dream that promised them freedom and autonomy. These immigrants were largely treated well, jumping into the melting pot that was quickly becoming the American populus. Despite this, the country had a way to go after passing policies such as the Chinese Exclusion Act and harboring subtle nativist sentiment.⁵

While cultural changes and better working conditions were at the forefront of domestic policy, it was during the first two decades of the 20th century that America stretched her wings and flew to lands beyond its border. During its “Imperial Surge,” the United States stretched its sphere of influence to encompass neighboring lands, including Mexico, Nicaragua, Cuba, and Venezuela. America’s economy penetrated the region, exercising control of all deep sea routes. This control over trade was the first step to America becoming the global superpower that it is today. It was during this growth that the American people sought a larger navy, following the Monroe Doctrine and the Roosevelt Corollary in their actions, their blood filled with Manifest Density.⁶

Then World War One occurs, testing the new military and economic might of the United States in 1917. As the war dragged on, many Americans were forced to deal with the irony of fighting a war to protect a minority while simultaneously oppressing their own minority back home. While this does not cause immediate changes, it plants the seeds that would lead to the

³ Nancy Mitchell, “Then & Now; and the Chicago World Fair,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

⁴ Nancy Mitchell, “The Labor Movement & the Progressive Movement,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

⁵ Nancy Mitchell, “The Women’s Movement & Immigration,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

⁶ Nancy Mitchell, “Extracontinental Empire, Part 1,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

cultural acceptance of African Americans as a natural part of the American population. During the war, the Spanish Flu circled the world for several years, its high death rate decimating populations and killing an estimated 100 million people. Throughout the devastation, international and intranational reporting about the flu was kept to a minimum, opting to preserve the pleasant facade instead of shattering it with truth. The US practically denied the existence of the flu even as it was ravaging its soldiers, and people seldom talked about the deadly disease. Only when the Spanish Flu came knocking at their door was it tackled, and even then almost as a passing thought. This, I believe, was done in an effort to continue the grand American Dream. For how could a country who was suffering under the thumb of such a deadly disease stand atop the podium of the world and proclaim its greatness, both to its own people and to foreigners? Instead, hide the existence of the disease and continue your charade of greatness. Even though people were still dying up until the final wave in 1920, in 1919 the United States was considered a world power by those calling the shots. To be precise, the United States was involved in the Treaty of Versailles, what I would consider one of the keystone moments in America's rise to power. France, The United Kingdom, Italy, and The United States gathered together to discuss the world after the defeat of Germany. In this meeting, many details about the handling of Germany were ironed out, each of them important in their own right. Yet I believe that the greatest accomplishment of the treaty was the rollout of American control over free trade. Because the war decimated European economies and disrupted world trade, there was suddenly an economic power vacuum, allowing the United States to step in with its roaring economic engine, fresh from the demands of the war. In addition, the treaty stipulated the retreat of colonial power, meaning America could begin to use both their naval control of the seas and their economic engine to search for new, independent markets. This perfect storm of factors is what I believe to be one of the defining reasons why America is a top superpower today, as evidenced by the supremacy of the dollar and American multinational conglomerates.^{7 8}

The story post-WWI shifts back domestically, as the once distant threat of Communism rises into fear that grips the nation, the time known as the First Red Scare. The fear that the push for worker's rights, which resulted in country-wide strikes, would lead the country down a path that ended in anarchy. The Red Scare grew hand in hand to toxic nationalism. While Jim Crow laws and lynchings remained a constant pressure on African Americans in the south, the Quota Act of 1924 limited immigration into the country in an effort to keep the United States an Anglo-Saxon nation. This, in addition to the Palmer Raids, which targeted Jews, radicals, gay's, and non-whites, were all flavors of the new Eugenics Movement. Prohibition and the KKK flourished under this new "purified" American Dream, becoming the mainstream appeal in the 1920's. This directly contributed to the US's efforts on an international level, with the country appealing to peace movements such as the Geneva Protocols, the Kellogg Briand Pact, and later the Neutrality Act. The US was focused both in internal purification and external purification,

⁷ Nancy Mitchell, "World War One & the 1918 Flu, Part 1," Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

⁸ Nancy Mitchell, "World War One & the 1918 Flu, Part 2," Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

seeking to maintain cordial yet separated relationships with European countries, known today as the “isolationist movement.”^{9 10}

Unfortunately, the 1930’s began with the Great Depression. Banks were out of money, people were struggling to feed their families, and President Hoover essentially told American Citizens that the problem would fix itself through Laissez Faire economics. The drastic decrease in quality of life for the average American was a threat to the golden American Dream, a threat that could not stand. This drive for a better life led to the great triumph that was FDR’s New Deals, a splattering of three letter administrations that whipped the country into shape, giving jobs to the jobless, providing housing to the homeless, regulated business in protection of the worker, and sanctioned areas of natural land for preservation of beauty. It was through increased worker pay, a bolstering of economic production, and a decrease in unemployment that the first and second New Deals helped lift the country out of the depression, putting it back on track to achieving the American Dream, a land of opportunity, equality, and happiness.^{11 12 13}

Then... World War Two. Despite burying their head in the sand for as long as possible, after Pearl Harbor the United States was forced to shift their attention from polishing their shiny, peaceful, whitewashed American Dream and dive into the dirty reality that were the Nazis. The threat of another war bolsters the country’s manufacturing once more, including the infamous Manhattan Project that created the atomic bomb. The pressure of manufacturing jobs and needed soldiers was the needed push to force the government to desegregate their armed forces, one of the first clumps of snow that led to the avalanche of civil rights. As the country entered the war, FDR’s “Four Freedoms” (Freedom of Religion, Freedom of Speech, Freedom from want, and Freedom from Fear) echo as yet another reincarnation of the American Dream.

By the end of the 1940’s, Germany has been defeated, the US has proved its military might with the events of Nagasaki and Hiroshima, and the world is once again recovering from the horrors of war. While the brutality of the atomic bombs were well documented, they were kept from the public. The cause and effects of this decision could be an entirely other paper, but I believe one of the greatest drivers of this decision was to maintain the purity of the American Dream within the American populace. Yet the atomic bombs did something more than just level two Japanese cities. They sparked the Cold War, the largest international hurdle the American Dream had ever come across, with repercussions that would include dissolution of governments, CIA orchestrated coups, multiple wars spanning decades, and the escalation of an arms race capable of destroying the world hundreds of times over. The Cold War was the ultimate test of the American Dream: how could the country that promised freedom and equality for all sit by and watch the world burn around them? No, it needed to spread its message throughout the world, protecting countries from the encroaching front of Russian communism and Chinese autocracy. FDR put it best in 1941, saying ““I tell the American people solemnly that the United

⁹ Nancy Mitchell, “The 1920’s,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹⁰ Nancy Mitchell, “The Interwar Era,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹¹ Nancy Mitchell, “The Great Depression,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹² Nancy Mitchell, “The New Deal, Part 1,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹³ Nancy Mitchell, “The New Deal, Part 2,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

States will never survive as a happy and fertile oasis of liberty surrounded by a cruel desert of Dictatorship.”¹⁴ The United States was no longer fighting WWII, but instead fighting the war of people’s minds, both domestically and abroad.^{15 16 17}

This is where the fight for the dream of American superiority and people’s rights split. While internationally, the country was achieving its goals, domestically the country still had a long way to go to reach the goal set out by the Declaration of Independence. Its tumultuous path forward was seen most clearly by minds like Fannie Lou Hamer, Malcolm X, W.E.B DuBois, and Martin Luther King Jr. The 1950’s and 60’s marked a dramatic shift in sentiment towards the treatment of African Americans across the country. Brutality under white racists, such as the story of Emmett Till, garnered national attention and scrutiny. Key court cases such as Brown v. The Board of Education and movements such as the Montgomery Bus Boycott and Freedom Rides soon paved the way for a brighter future. Slowly, the American Dream was being realized for every American, regardless of skin color or gender. It culminated in three important events: The Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, and the march on Washington in 1963, wherein Martin Luther King Jr. gave his famous “I have a Dream” speech. Each of these events marked a shift in American Culture, and the American Dream was refined once more.^{18 19}

The following three decades, 1960-1990, were a flurry of legislation, cultural reform, and international actions, slowly bringing the Cold War to its knees. The US waged war in Vietnam, Korea, Afghanistan, Nicaragua, and the Persian Gulf, clawing their way to the top. Each step was done strategically to bring down the Soviet Union, a plan which succeeded in 1991, making the end of the Cold War. Since that year, the US has had several international missions, notably the War on Terror and the Carter Doctrine. To this day, the United States is in a constant battle to maintain its position as a superpower, using its military and economic might to perpetuate the Dream of American Superiority. Despite its success abroad, its domestic dream, that of life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness, has been stuck in a rut. From the Gay Rights movement in the 1990’s to the battle against abortion rights today, the progress on expanding human and civil rights has been slow yet unrelenting. Even today, the American Dream is still held firm in the minds of millions of Americans, growing and changing as they actualize their desires of freedom and equality.^{20 21 22}

As America moves forward into the future, the dream held by its people will ensure its growth into a nation that triumphs in its economic, military, and cultural might, showing to the world that it truly is the greatest nation in the world. That, I believe, is the American Dream; to live in a nation that promotes equality, civility, and economic freedom while maintaining its

¹⁴ Nancy Mitchell, “The Interwar Era,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹⁵ Nancy Mitchell, “World War Two,” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹⁶ Nancy Mitchell, “The Origins of the Cold War, Part 1” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹⁷ Nancy Mitchell, “The Origins of the Cold War, Part 2” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹⁸ Nancy Mitchell, “The Cold War at Home” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

¹⁹ Nancy Mitchell, “The Kennedy & Early Johnson Years” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

²⁰ Nancy Mitchell, “Reagan, Bush & the End of the Cold War” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

²¹ Nancy Mitchell, “The First Gulf War & the Gay Rights Movement” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

²² Nancy Mitchell, “The War on terror” Lecture for HI 254-601, Fall 2024

position as a global superpower. How the nation will proceed is in the hands of its people, guided by the knowledge of the past.